

sales tactic maneuvers, the urgency of the limited-time deal, and the illusion of a slashed discounted price. I eventually stopped chasing the blue light, but I never stopped looking for clearance signs. I would succumb to many sales tactics in the ensuing years, but falling for the blue light special was a rookie mistake—the “good deal” that really wasn’t.

One of my daughters coined the phrase “It made me read it,” about the pull of a good book, and I intimately understand the concept. For any avid reader, there exists that phenomenon of being unable to stop reading until we’ve turned that last page. For me, it is any book by author Jodi Picoult. Never mind my best intentions, I’ve learned from experience to never begin one of her books unless I am certain I’ll have the time to finish it by day’s end. The bleary-eyed daughter unable to be roused in the morning because of binge reading in the bathroom or underneath her covers until four in the morning said it best, “That book made me read it.”

So it is with the heavily discounted merchandise and the clearance items I had coupons for. “I had to buy it,” I’d explain to my perplexed husband. “It was 90% off and free with my coupons.” That is why a coupon enthusiast might come home with bags of cat treats when they don’t have any pets or ten packages of Lunchables with fruit when their children don’t even like the product. For most of my life, I just couldn’t resist a sale price, especially when a coupon resulted in a free item, or something that cost just pennies with the extra savings.

Coupons are just one of the many ways manufacturers entice the consumer to purchase their product. But what makes one person respond so strongly to a coupon or rebate offer while another ignores the sale price or